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Vision and Formation in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry:

A Study of Semantics and Aesthetics

الرؤيا والتشكيل في شعر محمد الفيتوري: بحث في الدلالات والجماليات

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Abstract

This study undertakes an in-depth analysis of the dialectic between vision and formation in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetry, illuminating how his ideas, concerns, and conceptions are manifested through the artistic and linguistic tools he skillfully employs. It seeks to explore the organic relationship between the content and form of his poetry, demonstrating how language, imagery, rhythm, and symbolism contribute to embodying his vision and presenting it in its most aesthetically refined forms. The study employs an analytical approach to poetic texts, utilizing thematic and stylistic methodologies to deconstruct the elements of vision and formation and examine their interplay. This research aims to highlight the aesthetic and semantic dimensions that characterize Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetry, affirming his stature as a poet of inspiring vision and exceptional artistic prowess.

Key Words: Formation, meaning, Muhammad Al-Fayturi, aesthetics.,

الملخص:

تتناول هذه الدراسة بالتحليل المعمق جدلية الرؤية والتشكيل في شعر محمد الفيتوري، مُسلطة الضوء على الكيفية التي تتجلى بها أفكاره وقضاياه وتصوراتهِ من خلال الأدوات الفنية واللغوية التي وظّفها ببراعة. وتسعى إلى استكشاف العلاقة العضوية بين مضمون شعره وشكله، مُبيّنة كيف ساهمت اللغة والصورة والإيقاع والرمز في تجسيد رؤيته وتقديمها في أبهى صورها الجمالية. تعتمد الدراسة على منهج تحليلي للنصوص الشعرية، مع الاستعانة بالمقاربة الموضوعاتية والمنهج الأسلوبي لتفكيك عناصر الرؤية والتشكيل والكشف عن تفاعلاتها.

يهدف هذا البحث إلى إبراز الجوانب الجمالية والدلالية التي تميز شعر محمد الفيتوري، وتأكيد مكانته كشاعر صاحب رؤية مُلهمة وقدرة فنية فائقة.

الكلمات المفتاحية: التشكيل، الدلالة، محمد الفيتوري، الجمالية.

Introduction

The Sudanese poet Mohammed Al-Fitouri (1936-2015) stands as a prominent figure in modern Arabic poetry and a pioneer who led the movement of poetic renewal, transcending the constraints of traditional forms to establish the aesthetics of free verse. Al-Fitouri's poetry was not merely an expression of the poet's self; rather, it encompassed a profound and comprehensive vision of the world, humanity, and the cosmos—a vision shaped through his engagement with the issues of his era and his existential and spiritual contemplations. The dynamic interaction between this rich vision and the innovative poetic forms he crafted to express it is precisely what lends his

poetic experience its uniqueness and profound impact on the recipient.

Chapter One: The Poetic Vision of Mohammed Al-Fitouri: In-depth Details and Analyses

Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetic vision is characterized by its depth and comprehensiveness, addressing pivotal issues that have occupied humanity and society throughout the ages. The salient features of this vision can be discerned in his focus on issues of freedom and liberation, identity and belonging, as well as Sufism and spirituality, in addition to his contemplations on the nature of humanity and existence.

1.1 Issues of Freedom and Liberation

The issue of freedom constituted a fundamental core in Al-Fitouri's poetry, as he expressed his profound rejection of

all forms of colonialism, injustice, and oppression. His vision of freedom was not confined to national liberation from the clutches of colonialism but extended to encompass comprehensive human liberation from all constraints that shackle the soul and mind. This vision manifested in many of his poems, adopting diverse expressive forms, from direct discourse to symbolism and allusion.

In his renowned poem (Ode to Africa), Al-Fitouri articulates his vision of Africa¹

1.2. Identity and Belonging

The issue of identity and belonging constitutes another pivotal concern that preoccupied Al-Fitouri's thought and poetry. Given his upbringing in diverse cultural environments (Sudan, Egypt, Lebanon, Libya, and Morocco) and his engagement with the issues facing his Arab and African nations, his poetry expressed the complexities of this issue and the internal conflicts arising from multiple affiliations. Al-Fitouri's poetry sought to transcend narrow identity dualisms, emphasizing the unifying human dimension.

In his poem (Remember Me, Africa), this interplay between self-belonging and African roots emerges as he addresses Africa with an intimate call, expressing a profound connection:

***Remember me whenever night comes
bearing its dark specters.***

***Remember me whenever dawn appears,
smiling with its radiant mouth***

Here, the poet links himself to Africa across various circumstances and conditions ("whenever night comes," "whenever dawn appears"). Night can be interpreted as a symbol for challenges and difficulties, and dawn as a symbol for hope and new beginnings, indicating

as a cradle of liberty and a wellspring of revolutionaries, employing powerful, hope-filled language:

Africa...

***O cradle of the free,
O mine of revolutionaries
O dawn's rising***

These verses reflect the poet's vision of Africa as a symbol of rebirth and liberation, depicting it as fertile ground that nurtures the free and the revolutionary, and as a source of light and hope.

Africa's constant presence in the poet's consciousness and experience.²

Furthermore, in the poem (Song of Senegal), Al-Fitouri expresses his pride in his African roots and his spiritual bond with the land of his ancestors, using language rich with poeticism and history:

***O land of my ancestors, O descent of
revelation, O Kaaba of revolutionaries,
O cradle of redemption, in every atom
of your hills, a story, and in every star
in your sky, a light.***

The poet here imbues his portrayal of Africa with historical and spiritual dimensions, referring to it with deeply connotative phrases ("descent of revelation," "Kaaba of revolutionaries," "cradle of redemption"). This connection reflects Al-Fitouri's vision of African identity as an intrinsic part of his being and memory.³

2.1. The Dimension of African Identity and Belonging in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry: A Search for Roots and Self

African belonging forms a fundamental pillar in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetic identity and his worldview. This affiliation was not merely an emotional yearning for the motherland but a deep awareness of shared history, rich cultural heritage, and the challenges facing the

African continent in its pursuit of liberation and progress. This dimension is evident in many of his poems, taking various forms, from direct expression to historical and geographical symbolism and allusion.

2.1.1. Nostalgia for Africa and Roots:

Al-Fitouri's poetry reveals a profound nostalgia for Africa as the cradle of civilizations and the fount of authenticity. He expresses this yearning by evoking African natural imagery, recalling childhood and associated memories, and emphasizing a spiritual connection to the land.

In his poem (Songs of Africa), he declares this deep connection from the outset:

*Africa... O melody of my being, O pulse
of my blood, O secret of my ascent*

Al-Fitouri here portrays Africa as an intrinsic part of his existence ("melody of my being," "pulse of my blood"), and even links to it the secret of his spiritual and intellectual growth ("secret of my ascent"). This indicates that African belonging is not merely a geographical affiliation but a part of the poet's deep identity.

In (Return to Africa), nostalgia manifests as a desire to return to the origin and regain pristine purity:

*I shall return, Africa, to your warm
bosom, to wash from my soul the dust of
false Westernization.*

The poet depicts Africa as a warm embrace and a safe haven ("your warm bosom"), and views returning to it as a purification of the soul from the effects of cultural and intellectual alienation ("the dust of false Westernization"). This expresses a vision of Africa as a spiritual and identity-based center for the poet.

2.1.2. Awareness of Shared History and Suffering:

Al-Fitouri's poetry demonstrates a deep awareness of Africa's **shared history**, including periods of colonialism, slavery, and the struggle for liberation. He expresses this suffering and draws strength from it for the future.

In his poem (Wounds of Africa), he depicts the effects of colonialism as deep wounds on the continent's body:

*O Africa... O continent of wounds, you
bleed blood... and cry out in pain Yet in
your eyes, a glimmer of hope, and in
your blood... the strength of struggle.*

The poet here does not merely depict pain and suffering ("you bleed blood," "and cry out in pain") but also points to the inherent strength of hope and resistance within the continent ("a glimmer of hope," "the strength of struggle"). This vision reflects an awareness of challenges but also a belief in Africa's ability to overcome them.

In a poem addressing the period of slavery, Al-Fitouri evokes painful images of human suffering:

*The executioner's whips on my back
and the slave's cry in my night will not
erase from my memory the coming
dawn of freedom.*

The poet expresses individual and collective pain and suffering ("the executioner's whips," "the slave's cry") but simultaneously affirms faith in a future of freedom ("the coming dawn of freedom"). This connection between the painful past and the bright future reveals an awareness of history as a driving force toward liberation.

2.1.3 Celebrating African Culture and Heritage

Al-Fitouri's poetry celebrates the rich and diverse African culture and heritage, invoking symbols, myths, and folk tales that express a distinct African identity. In some of his poems, he may allude to cultural symbols or African myths to add

historical and aesthetic depth to his verse. For example, he might invoke names of historical African figures or symbols from popular folklore to express certain values or refer to significant historical periods.

He also highlights the beauty and diversity of African nature as part of the continent's cultural identity:

O brown one, O my land, O Nile, O my river, In your green plains, my flowers bloom.

The poet addresses Africa with the epithet "the brown one," referring to the skin color of its people and the beauty of its nature. He links the land and the Nile as symbols of life and fertility on the continent. These images convey a sense of pride in Africa's natural and cultural beauty.

2.1.4. African Unity and Solidarity

Al-Fitouri believes in the unity of Africa and the necessity of solidarity among its peoples in confronting shared challenges. This vision is manifested in his call for transcending artificial borders and working together for a better future for the continent.

In some of his poems, he issues appeals to the peoples of Africa to unite and cooperate:

O my brothers in Africa, rise up to build a tomorrow, We break the chains of the past and plant our land with roses.

The poet here calls for unity and cooperation ("O my brothers in Africa") to build a better future ("rise up to build a tomorrow"), overcome the effects of the colonial past ("break the chains of the past"), and achieve prosperity ("plant our land with roses").

3.1 Sufism and Spirituality

The **Sufi and spiritual dimension** is a striking feature of Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetic experience. His poetry shows a clear inclination towards

transcending the material world and seeking the absolute and universal truth. This vision manifests through the use of Sufi language and symbolic references that reflect a deep spiritual experience and connection to the cosmos.

In his poem (Lover from Africa), this spiritual dimension can be discerned in his depiction of love as a state of unity and integration with the other, alluding to the concept of annihilation in Sufism:

I am the lover who was lost in your eyes and did not ask About the path or where to go... I am the thirsty one who, whenever sated, saw In your eyes wine and a trumpet.

The poet here portrays a state of complete absorption in the beloved ("lost in your eyes"), transcending concern for material details ("the path or where to go"). He also alludes to a state of perpetual yearning ("the thirsty one who whenever sated"), finding in the beloved what quenches his spiritual thirst ("wine and a trumpet"). These verses can be interpreted within the context of the Sufi experience, which seeks union with the divine self or absolute truth through spiritual love and adoration.⁴

In the poem (The Sad Flute), the poet's vision of existential unity and a sense of belonging to the universe is revealed in a state of silent contemplation:

I am alone... And the long night, and bewildered melodies... Flow, dissolve in the silence of existence, and complain... with no one to answer.⁵

These verses reflect a feeling of solitude in the face of the vastness of the universe ("the long night"), where the individual ego dissolves into the "silence of existence." The "sad flute" can be interpreted as a symbol of the human soul expressing its bewilderment and longing in this vast existence. This state points to a Sufi vision that sees unity

with the cosmos and spiritual tranquility as a goal and purpose. He also states in the poem (A Melody for a Wandering Dervish):

*My soul has turned pale, become a twilight,
It shone as a cloud and a radiance.
Like the dervish clinging to the feet of his master,
I wallow in my sorrow,
I glow in my body.
Others are blind; no matter how they listen, they will not see me.
For I am a body, a stone, something crossing the street,
Drowned islands at the bottom of the sea, A fire in lost time, a faint oil lamp in the furthest house,
In Beirut. I gleam for a moment, then fade, then die.
Woe is me! As I stammer towards You, my Master, I strip away my sorrows,
I embody You. Are You me?
Is it Your outstretched hand or my outstretched hand? Your voice or my voice? Do You make me cry or do I cry for You?
In the presence of the one I love, yearnings played havoc with me. I gazed without a face and danced without legs.
And I filled the horizons with my banners and drums. My love annihilates my love, and my annihilation is absorption. Your slave, yet I am the Sultan of lovers!*⁶

These verses offer a glimpse into the poem's depth, expressing a state of annihilation in the beloved (whether God, homeland, or absolute truth) and spiritual manifestation.

3.1.1. Unity of Existence and Connection with the Cosmos

Al-Fitouri's poetry reveals a profound sense of unity with existence, where the boundaries between the individual self

and the expansive cosmos dissolve. He expresses this feeling of connection through poetic imagery that blurs the distinctions between humanity and nature, and points to a unity of source and purpose.

In his poem (Anthem of the Soul), this holistic vision is manifested:

*I am a drop in the ocean of existence,
And the entire ocean is in my being. I am a part of the whole, and the whole is revealed in my witnessing.*

3.1.2. Humanity and Existence

Mohammed Al-Fitouri profoundly contemplates the nature of humanity, its existence, destiny, and relationship with the cosmos in his poetry. His poems raise existential questions about the meaning of life and death, time and space, freedom and fate. These contemplations reflect a deep philosophical and humanistic vision.

In his poem (The Fall of the Last Knight), Al-Fitouri addresses the idea of transformation and renewal through the image of the fallen knight:

O knight who fell from his wounded steed, Did you find in the fall the meaning of a new rise?

These verses pose a question about the possibility of fall and defeat serving as the beginning of a new resurgence and renewed strength. The image of the "wounded knight" suggests human vulnerability and constraints, while the question about "the meaning of a new rise" carries an optimistic vision of the possibility of transcendence and change. In the poem (Tomorrow We Meet), Al-Fitouri expresses a vision imbued with hope and optimism for the future, even in the most challenging circumstances:

*Tomorrow we meet... At the crossroads.
Tomorrow... When the stone blossoms
And grass grows in flames.*

These verses use seemingly impossible images ("the stone blossoms," "grass grows in flames") to convey the power of hope and the belief in the possibility of the impossible becoming real in the future ("Tomorrow we meet"). This vision reflects a deep faith in life's ability to renew itself and overcome difficulties.
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3.1.3. Seeking Absolute Truth and Transcending Dualities

The Sufi inclination drives Al-Fitouri in his poetry to seek a higher truth that transcends the limits of the sensory and rational world. This is evident in his use of symbolic imagery that refers to this transcendent realm, and in his attempt to transcend traditional dualities (such as good and evil, light and darkness) in pursuit of a deeper unity.

In some of his poems, he uses the image of "light" as a symbol for the divine truth or spiritual knowledge he seeks:

O you who walk in darkness, Search for the light hidden deep within your self, For it is the guide and the mentor.

The image of "darkness" here refers to a state of ignorance or distance from truth, while "the light hidden deep within the self" indicates the inner potential to realize this truth. The poet calls for inner search and self-contemplation as a means to attain spiritual knowledge.

The transcendence of dualities is also evident in some of his verses that refer to the unity of source despite apparent differences:

From the desolation of solitude, the universe emerges. In the multiplicity of forms, unity is revealed.

These verses reflect a Sufi vision that sees the universe, with all its diversity and difference, emanating from a single source ("the desolation of solitude"), and that this apparent multiplicity is merely a manifestation of this underlying unity.

1.3.4. Emotional Experience and Spiritual Longing

Al-Fitouri's poetry portrays deep emotional states that allude to the Sufi experience, such as longing for the absolute, annihilation in the beloved (in its spiritual sense), and a sense of bewilderment and wonder in the face of the grandeur of existence.

In another poem from "Lover from Africa" spiritual longing is manifested as perpetual thirst:

My thirst for you is never quenched, And every quenching increases my yearning. O secret of this wondrous universe, Where can I escape my burning?

The poet here expresses an insatiable spiritual longing ("my thirst for you is never quenched"), where even proximity intensifies this yearning ("every quenching increases my yearning"). He refers to "the secret of this wondrous universe" as the source of this deep longing and expresses a state of spiritual burning resulting from this perpetual search.

The state of bewilderment and wonder in the face of the grandeur of existence is also evident in other verses:

Oh, what a mystery of existence! It deepens the more I understand, And the closer I get one step, A thousand distances recede.

These verses reflect an awareness of the complexity and grandeur of existence, where the more understanding increases, the horizons expand, and the distance to absolute truth grows. This bewilderment indicates a fundamental characteristic of the Sufi experience: surrendering to the inability of the human mind to fully comprehend divine truth.

3.1.5. Use of Sufi Symbols

Al-Fitouri employs some symbols with traditional Sufi connotations in his

poetry, such as "light," "wine" (in its spiritual sense), "ecstasy," and "annihilation." However, he does not use these symbols in a rigid, traditional manner; rather, he imbues them with new dimensions that align with his poetic experience and unique vision.

As previously noted, "light" is used as a symbol for spiritual knowledge and divine truth. In the Sufi context, "wine" refers to spiritual ecstasy and divine intoxication resulting from proximity to the truth. This meaning may appear in some of his verses that speak of intoxication or rapture in a way that suggests spiritual significance.

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Chapter Two: Poetic Formation in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry: An Aesthetic and Stylistic Study

Al-Fitouri's poetic vision wasn't merely abstract ideas; it was embodied in innovative and aesthetic poetic forms, where he masterfully utilized language, imagery, rhythm, and symbolism to convey his vision to the recipient with profound impact.

1.1. Poetic Language

Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetic language is characterized by its richness, precision, and mellifluousness, with a remarkable ability to express the subtlest emotions and deepest thoughts. His language varies between tenderness and evocation, and strength and eloquence, depending on the subject matter and the emotional context of the poem.

In his poem "(Song for New Love), the tenderness and mellifluousness of his language are evident in depicting the beauty of life and hope:

***Come... For life here Sings for the
morning And plays for the winds the
anthems of triumph.***

Al-Fitouri here uses verbs imbued with movement and life ("sings," "plays") to imbue nature with vitality and joy. He also links this vibrancy to simple and evocative images ("morning," "winds," "anthems of triumph") to create an atmosphere of optimism and hope.

Conversely, his language is characterized by strength and eloquence in other poems that address more intense issues, as seen in the poem (Do Not Reconcile), where he used powerful and impactful phrases to express the rejection of injustice.

1.2. Poetic Imagery

The use of poetic imagery is one of the most prominent characteristics of Al-Fitouri's style. His images are distinguished by their vibrancy and innovation; he blends the sensory with the abstract, employing similes, metaphors, metonymy, and synecdoche to create poetic worlds rich in connotations and allusions.

In his poem (River of Sorrows), he uses the image of a river to express the depth and continuity of sorrow:

*Your eyes... my lady, two rivers of
yearning Flowing in my blood and
burning my years.*

Here, Al-Fitouri transforms the beloved's eyes into "two rivers of yearning," a powerful image that embodies the depth of longing and pain residing within the poet. He further enriches this image with the notion of continuous movement ("flowing in my blood") and destructive impact ("burning my years"), deepening the reader's sense of the intensity of this sorrow.

In his poem (Africa's Night), he uses the image of night to express the continent's history and civilizational depth:

*O dark night of Africa, O ancient
silence of my ancestors, Generations
sleep in your eyes, And resolve awakens
in your blood.*

Al-Fitouri here personifies the African night as a living entity that carries within it the history of ancestors ("ancient silence of my ancestors") and successive civilizations ("generations sleep in your eyes"). Conversely, he alludes to the

potential for future strength latent in the blood of present generations ("resolve awakens in your blood"). This image unites past, present, and future in a single poetic vision.

2. Poetic Imagery in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry: Embodying Visions and Intensifying Connotations

Poetic imagery is the cornerstone in constructing Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetic worlds. His poetry is characterized by rich and diverse depictions, where imagery is not limited to clarification and adornment but extends to become a primary means of embodying visions and ideas and intensifying deep connotations. His deployment of imagery ranges from simplicity to complexity, and from the sensory to the abstract, lending his poetry a unique vitality and impact.

2.1. Diverse Sources of Poetic Imagery:

Al-Fitouri draws his poetic images from various sources, including:

✓ **African Nature:** He evokes elements of rich and diverse African nature (night, sun, Nile, desert, forests, animals) to express his feelings, thoughts, and concerns. We observe in his depiction of Africa that he often uses the image of night ("dark night of Africa") to denote historical depth or mystery, while using the image of the sun or dawn ("dawn's rising") to signify hope and liberation.

✓ **Daily Life:** He captures images from daily life and human interactions to infuse his poetry with realism and vitality. This can be seen in his elegy for Baghdad:

*Poetry and poets arrive In a time of
light's splintering,*

*Poetry and poets arrive, Their
gazes fixed on Baghdad,
Our Kaaba, at whose thresholds
The sun of the Magi bowed down.⁸
Peace be upon you, O ruby of Al-
Mansour.*

- ✓ **History and Current Events:** He draws inspiration from historical events and contemporary political occurrences to express his stance and vision regarding them.

- Example: His use of the image of "the fallen knight" in his poem of the same name to express transformation and renewal within a historical or personal context.

- ✓ **Inner World and Human Emotions:** He embodies his inner feelings and emotions through sensory and tangible images.

- Example: Transforming eyes into "two rivers flowing in my blood" in the poem "River of Sorrows."

2.2.Functions of Poetic Imagery:

Poetic imagery in Al-Fitouri's poetry serves multiple functions, including:

- ✓ **Sensory Embodiment of Abstract Ideas:** He transforms abstract ideas and concepts into tangible sensory images, making them clearer and more impactful for the recipient.
 - Example: Embodying the idea of injustice through the image of "gouging out an eye" and presenting "the crutch and gold."
- ✓ **Expression of Emotions and Feelings:** Poetic images help convey emotions and feelings

directly and powerfully to the reader.

- Example: The image of "two rivers of yearning" powerfully expresses the depth of longing and pain.

- ✓ **Semantic Intensification and Allusion:** Poetic imagery carries multiple meanings and connotations that extend beyond the literal meaning, enriching the text and opening vast possibilities for interpretation.

- Example: The image of "night" can allude to mystery, antiquity, sorrow, or even latent power, depending on the context.

- ✓ **Creation of Psychological and Emotional Atmosphere:** Images contribute to building the overall atmosphere of the poem and defining the psychological and emotional state experienced by the poet or sought to be conveyed.

- Example: The images of joy and life in the poem "Song for New Love" create an optimistic atmosphere.

2.3. The Employment of Myth and Symbol in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry: Invoking Historical and Universal Depth

The employment of myth and symbol is a crucial technique that Mohammed Al-Fitouri relies upon in his poetry to impart historical and universal depth to his vision, and to move beyond direct expression towards allusion and suggestion.

2.3.1. Employment of Myth:

The employment of myth is not a pervasive element in Al-Fitouri's poetry compared to some poets of his generation, but it appears in specific

instances to serve particular semantic purposes. He might invoke mythical figures or symbolic tales from human or African heritage to project them onto contemporary reality or to express abstract ideas.

Potential Examples: We might find fleeting references to certain Greek myths (such as Sisyphus to denote futility or continuous suffering, or Phoenix to denote resurrection and renewal) or to symbols from African myths (if they serve the context of his poems about identity and belonging). Identifying these references requires meticulous textual analysis.

*I was the image, and the beloved, and the lover. When I stole the secret one night from the towering mountain of the gods, and returned to my prison, O Beirut.*⁹

These verses demonstrate the employment of the **Prometheus myth**. When Al-Fitouri utilizes myth, he often reinterprets it or imbues it with new connotations that align with his vision and the issues of his era, rather than simply recounting the mythical narrative in its original sense.

2.3.2. Employment of Symbol

Symbolism is an essential element in Al-Fitouri's poetry, utilized extensively to intensify meanings and broaden the scope of interpretation. The symbols he employs range from natural and social symbols to those with spiritual and existential dimensions.

Natural Symbols:

- ✓ **Night:** May symbolize ignorance, colonialism, the past, mystery, or even latent power.
- ✓ **Dawn/Sun:** Often symbolizes hope, freedom, new beginnings, light, and knowledge.

- ✓ **River:** May symbolize life, continuity, or sorrow (as in "River of Sorrows").
- ✓ **Earth:** Often symbolizes homeland, belonging, motherhood, and fertility.

Social and Political Symbols:

- ✓ **Chains/Bonds:** Symbolize enslavement, oppression, and loss of freedom.
- ✓ **Fallen Knight:** May symbolize apparent defeat that holds the potential for resurgence.
- ✓ **City:** May symbolize civilization, alienation, or the center of authority.

Spiritual and Existential Symbols:

- ✓ **Light:** Symbolizes spiritual truth, divine knowledge, and illumination.
- ✓ **Thirst/Quenching:** May symbolize spiritual longing and the search for the absolute.
- ✓ **Unity/Multiplicity:** Symbolize the concept of existential unity and its various manifestations.

Al-Fitouri's use of symbolism is characterized by its dynamism and flexibility, where a single symbol may carry different connotations depending on the poetic context. He frequently creates new symbols or imbues traditional symbols with contemporary meanings.

Examples of Interaction between Image and Symbol:

In his poem (Remember Me, Africa), image and symbol interact closely. The image of the night bearing dark specters may symbolize Africa's colonial past and periods of darkness, while the image of the smiling dawn may symbolize coming hope and liberation. Here, sensory

images are used to embody historical, political, and psychological symbols.

In (Lover from Africa), the image of "the thirsty one who, whenever sated, saw in your eyes wine and a trumpet" combines the sensory (thirst, quenching, wine) with the symbolic (wine as a symbol of spiritual ecstasy, trumpet as a symbol of spiritual attraction) to express a profound experience of spiritual love.

2.3.Rhythm and Music in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's Poetry: Between Liberation and Harmony

Rhythm and music are vital components in the structure of poetic verse, significantly contributing to its aesthetic and emotional impact. In Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetry, this element undergoes a notable transformation from adherence to traditional meters and rhymes to embracing the freedom of (poetic foot) in free verse, while maintaining an inner musicality that lends his poetry a distinctive harmony.

2.3.1. The Shift from Traditional Meter and Rhyme to the Metrical Foot "Taf'ila":

In his early poetic career, Al-Fitouri wrote some poems adhering to the traditional meters and rhymes of Arabic poetry. However, he soon immersed himself in the **free verse movement**, which adopts the *taf'ila* as the basic rhythmic unit and liberates itself from the constraints of a single meter and unified rhyme. This shift was not merely a change in form; rather, it was an expression of a new poetic vision seeking greater freedom in expression and aligning rhythm with the flow of emotion and thought. Most of Al-Fitouri's later collections adopt the free verse form. In these poems, the length of the poetic lines varies according to the emotional surge or idea being expressed.

The rhythm stems from the repetition of *taf'ilat* in diverse arrangements and from the phonetic harmony resulting from word choice and the distribution of vowels and consonants.

2.3.2. Internal Rhythm and Phonetic Harmony:

Despite his liberation from traditional meter and rhyme, Al-Fitouri's poetry maintained a deep musicality evident in the poem's internal rhythm. This rhythm is achieved through several means, the most important of which are:

1. Repetition of Words and Phrases:

The repetition of certain important words or phrases imparts a special cadence to the poem and emphasizes the intended meanings. For example, the repetition of the phrase "O Africa" in his poems addressing the continent creates a powerful emotional rhythm.

2. Syntactic Parallelism: The use of sentences or phrases with similar grammatical structures creates a type of rhythmic harmony. For example, in the poem (Remember Me, Africa), the parallelism between "Remember me whenever night comes" and "Remember me whenever dawn appears" creates an impactful rhythm with a noticeable effect on feeling and emotion.

3. Musicality of Words: The selection of words with harmonious musicality (in terms of letters and their vocalizations) lends captivating phonetic beauty to the poem. This is evident in his use of words with soft or resonant letters in a specific harmony that can evoke a sense of calm or power. For instance, frequently used whispered letters

include Hā', Fā', Hā', and Thā'. As for resonant, explosive letters, we find Ṭā', Khā', and Šād.

4. **Distribution of Vowels and Consonants:** The distribution of short and long vowels and silent consonants plays a role in shaping the internal rhythm of the poetic verse or line in a free verse poem.
5. **Natural Intonation of Language:** Al-Fitouri observes the natural intonation of the Arabic language, allowing the rhythm to flow in harmony with the current of meaning and emotion.

In the poem (Song for New Love), the rhythm is smoother and more melodious, aligning with the theme of love and hope:

*Come... For life here sings for the morning
And plays for the winds the anthems of triumph.*

Here, the use of active verbs ("sings," "plays") and the distribution of light vowels give the lines a flowing and joyful rhythm.

In (The Unique One), he says:

*And I am about to praise your era, but you,
O sacred human, of uniqueness and awe, are in truth a tyrant.*¹⁰

2.3.3. The Function of Rhythm and Music in Serving the Vision:

Rhythm and music in Al-Fitouri's poetry are not merely separate aesthetic elements; rather, they integrate with and serve the poetic vision. Rhythm can enhance meaning, express emotional states, and imbue the poem with a special impact.

- ✓ **Strong and Pressing Rhythm:** May be used to express rejection, anger, or revolutionary fervor.
- ✓ **Calm and Flowing Rhythm:** May be used to express nostalgia, contemplation, or tender emotions.
- ✓ **Rhythmic Variation:** Can reflect shifts in emotions or ideas within the same poem.

Conclusion

The analysis of rhythm and music in Mohammed Al-Fitouri's poetry demonstrates an evolution from adherence to tradition to liberation within the framework of free verse, while maintaining a strong internal musicality. Al-Fitouri relies on the repetition of words and phrases, syntactic parallelism, the musicality of words, and the distribution of vowels and consonants to create a rhythm that suits the poem's subject matter and emotional state, effectively serving the poetic vision.

⁷ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: Collection: The Lovers Come to You, 1st ed., 1992.

⁸ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: The Lovers Come to You, Baghdad, Beirut, 1992, p. 109.

⁹ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: The Collected Works, Volume Two, Beirut, 1979, p. 105.

¹⁰ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: The Bow of Night and the Bow of Day, p. 66.

¹ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: The Dawn's Rising Collection.

² Mohammed Al-Fitouri: Songs of Africa.

³ Ibid., p. 45.

⁴ Mohammed Al-Fitouri: A Lover from Africa, p. 67.

⁵ Ibid., p. 17.

⁶ A Melody for a Wandering Dervish, Beirut, 1970, p. 14.

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